

The Spanish Armada
Various events in the defeat of the Spanish Armada in August 1588 are combined in this painting: the English fireship attack off Calais, columns of smoke from the warning beacons lit in England, and even the appearance of Queen Elizabeth I on a white horse.

under military command, but sailors remained a general body of men who might sail in naval ships or merchant ships, or as privateers. Every sea power had to have a system for transferring its seagoing population into naval service in wartime. The Dutch banned merchant ships from sailing, forcing seamen to opt for naval employment. France registered its sailors, who were called up in "classes" and served their share of conscription. Britain used "press-gangs" to forcibly recruit sailors on shore and at sea, or tried to attract volunteers by offering bonuses to those who signed on. In a crisis, landsmen had to be accepted as extra muscle on board, a dilution of seafaring expertise that became acute for Britain during the Napoleonic Wars. Permanent bodies of naval officers developed very gradually. Until the late 17th century senior commanders were usually not seamen and the senior seamen on board were often merchant captains or privateers. A career structure for naval officers emerged only slowly.

Armada medal
Silver medals, depicting English naval galleons, were cast to commemorate the defeat of the Spanish Armada in 1588.



PRIVATEERS

The expense of maintaining navies encouraged states to turn to private enterprise as a way of financing sea warfare. Privateering ranged from the authorization of individual captains to prey upon the commerce of an enemy nation, to the mounting of major operations in which rulers, from England's Elizabeth I to France's Louis XIV, took a financial stake along with other wealthy individuals. At times, the marauding of privateers amounted to what we would now call state-backed terrorism. The exploits of Jean Bart, Piet Heyn, Francis Drake, and other famous "sea dogs" made them national heroes, but they were understandably denounced as pirates by the victims of their depredations. The distinction between privateer and naval vessels was not always clear, not only because they might fight alongside one another—as in the English resistance to the Spanish Armada in 1588—but because naval ships also operated with a profit motive, most navies offering prize money for the capture of enemy vessels and their cargoes.





